

EE4410 CYBER SECURITY OF POWER GRIDS

Assignment 4: Operational Technology Traffic Analysis

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[Link to Google Colab Notebook](#)

1 Network Traffic Time-Series Analysis

This section explores and compares the characteristics of IT and OT traffic using packet length analysis and time-series resampling methods.

1.1 Traffic Data Visualization

The boxplot in Figure 1 displays the packet length distributions across various protocols observed in the dataset. TLSv1.2 and HTTP show the highest packet lengths and widest spreads, with TLSv1.2 reaching values beyond 1700 bytes and many outliers. HTTP also shows high and relatively stable packet sizes.

In contrast, GOOSE traffic appears tightly clustered around a specific length (~180 bytes), with minimal spread and a single outlier. The SMB2 protocol also stands out. Its packet sizes are considerably higher than GOOSE and most other protocols, and its distribution exhibits a wider interquartile range, spanning roughly from 150 to 450 bytes, with several outliers reaching into the thousands.

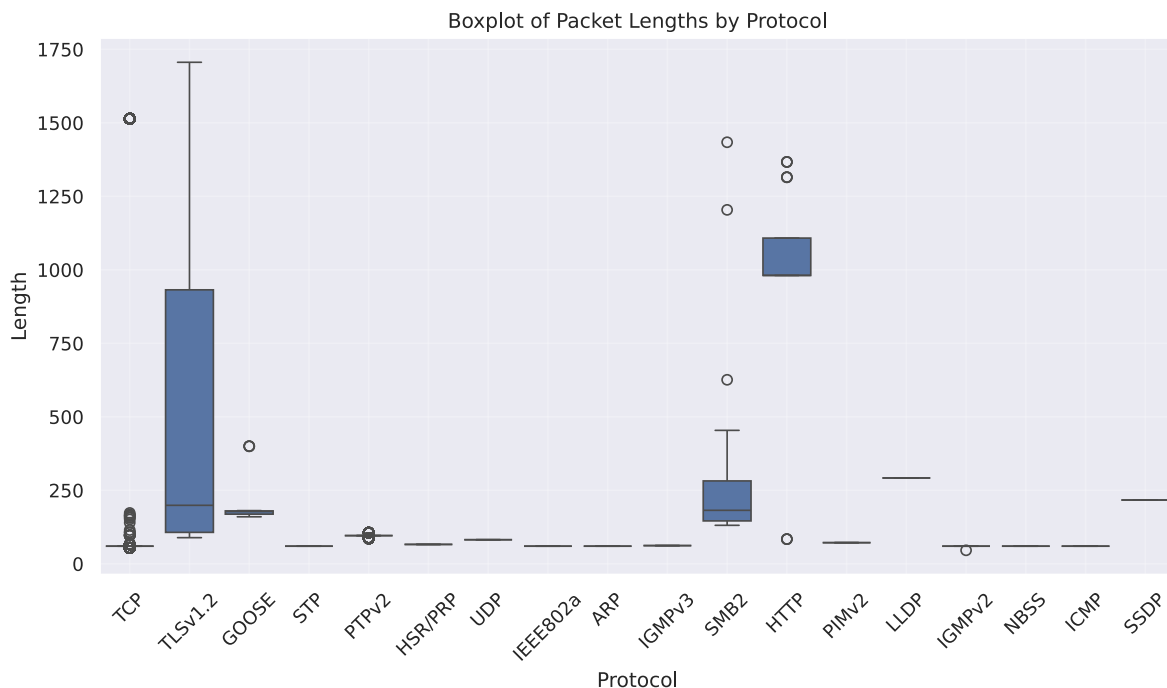


Figure 1: Boxplot of packet lengths across protocols

The temporal behavior of GOOSE traffic was further examined through the time-series plot shown in Figure 2. A repeating, burst-like pattern was clearly visible, indicating cyclic transmission.

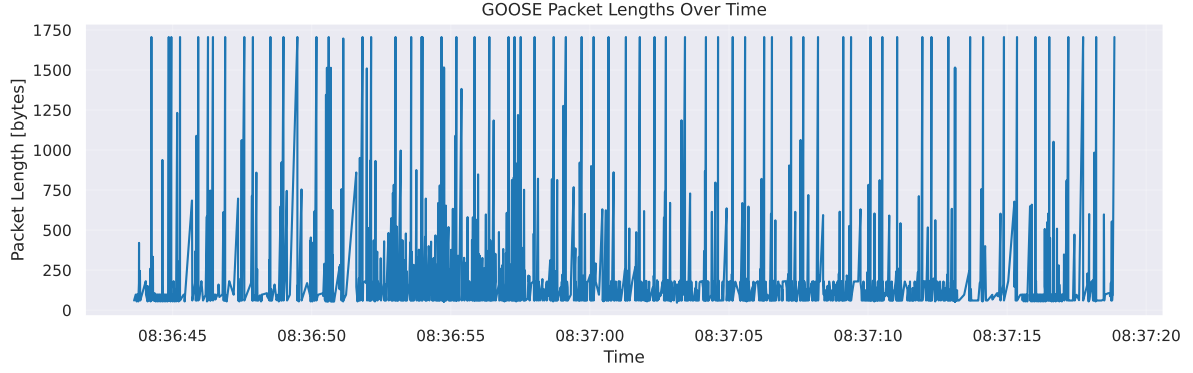


Figure 2: Time-series plot of GOOSE packet lengths

The repetitive structure is characteristic of status updates or synchronization messages, which are key features of GOOSE communication in power systems.

1.2 Resampling of The Times-Series Data

To assess traffic behavior across different time granularities, the packet length data was resampled using five intervals: 100ms, 200ms, 500ms, 1000ms, and 2000ms. The total packet length was aggregated over each window to observe temporal characteristics in both GOOSE and normal traffic. As shown in Figure 3, finer resampling intervals (e.g., 100ms and 200ms) preserved the bursty nature and variability in the traffic. In contrast, coarser intervals (e.g., 1000ms and 2000ms) tended to smooth out short-term variations, which can obscure meaningful anomalies or cycles.

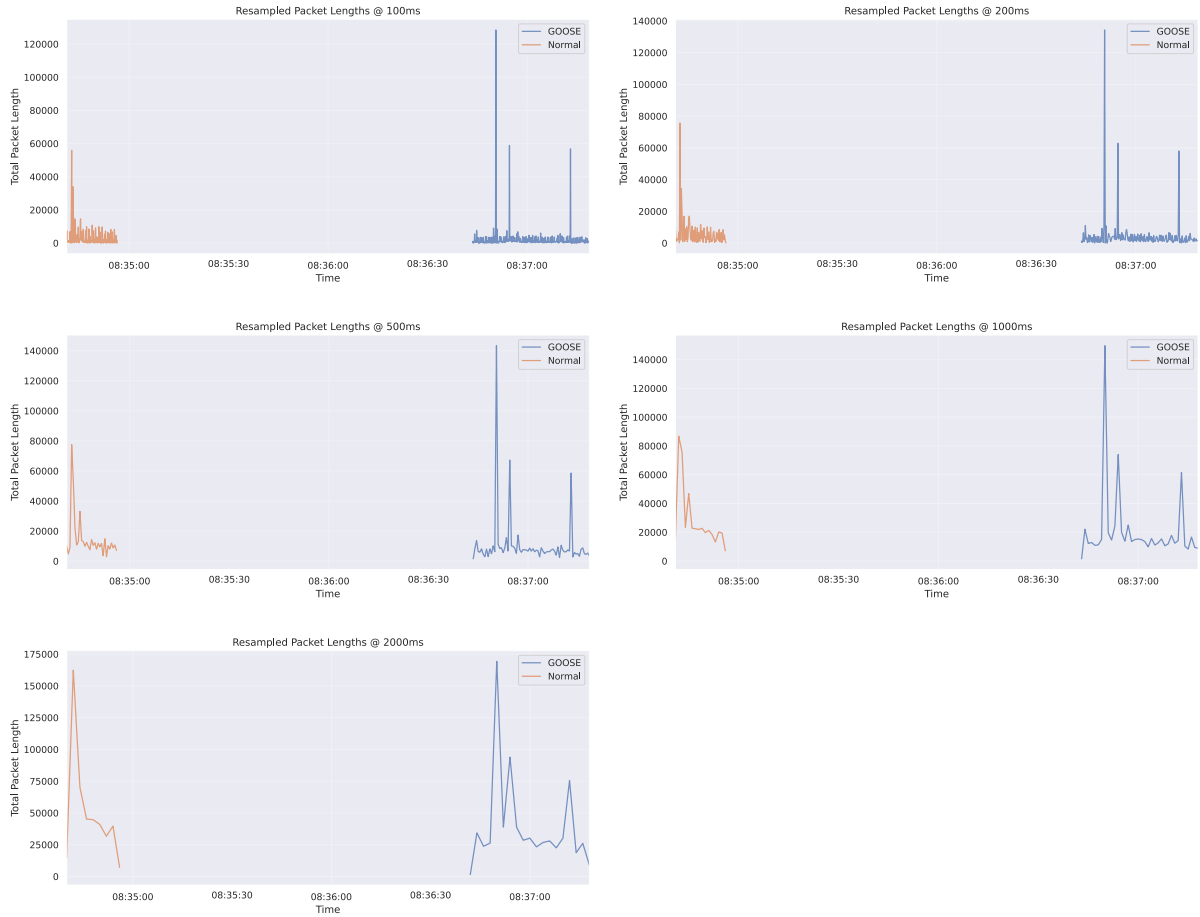


Figure 3: Comparison of resampled packet lengths at various intervals for both GOOSE and normal traffic

As the interval increases, the fine-grained fluctuations are smoothed out. Smaller intervals like 100 ms and 200 ms preserve temporal resolution and reveal micro-bursts, while larger intervals cause information loss due to aggregation.

Among the tested intervals, 200 ms was identified as a suitable compromise. It preserves temporal detail without excessive noise and retains distinguishable behavior between protocols. The plot in Figure 4 shows protocol-specific traffic dynamics at this resolution, revealing bursty behavior in GOOSE and relatively constant traffic in others (e.g., TCP, HTTP).

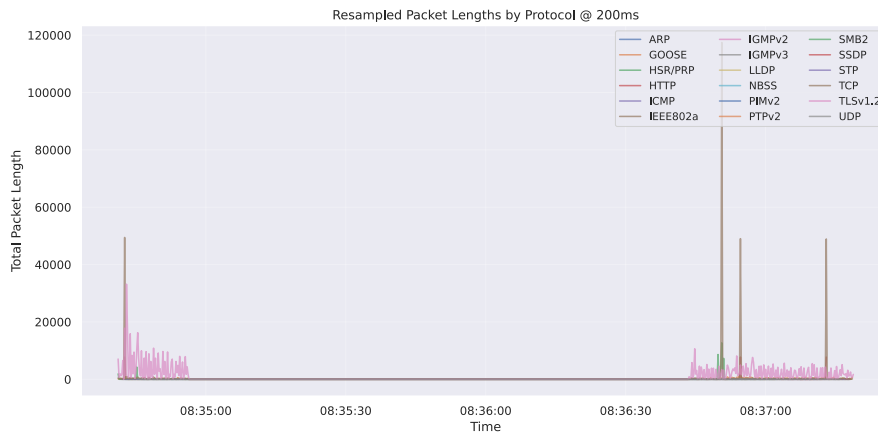


Figure 4: Resampled traffic for all protocols at 200ms

For GOOSE traffic in isolation, the 200 ms interval also proved effective. As depicted in Figure 5, periodic bursts and anomalies are retained with sufficient resolution, while noise is minimized. This confirms the selection of 200 ms as an optimal resampling setting for further GOOSE-specific analysis.

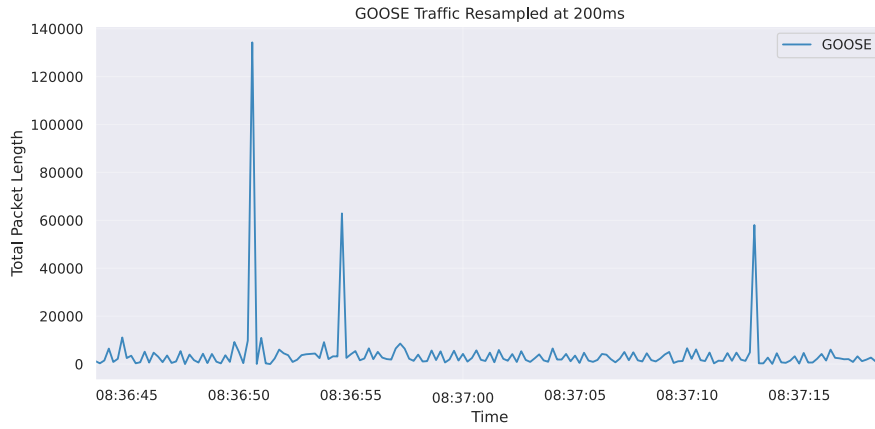


Figure 5: GOOSE traffic resampled at 200 ms, showing clear bursts and temporal consistency

1.3 Comparison and Anomaly Detection

Based on the boxplots and resampled visualizations (see Figure 1 and Figure 4), a clear distinction between OT and IT protocol behavior can be observed. **OT protocols** such as GOOSE exhibit highly cyclic and bursty traffic patterns. As shown in Figure 5, the GOOSE signal is periodic, with consistently sized packets appearing at regular intervals. This behavior aligns with the deterministic nature of substation automation systems where time-critical messages are broadcast repeatedly.

In contrast, **IT protocols** such as HTTP, TCP, and SMB demonstrate a broader spread in packet length and more irregular fluctuations. As visible in Figure 1, the interquartile ranges for these protocols are wide, and several extreme outliers are present. These characteristics reflect the stochastic and user-driven nature of IT communication, typical in office or administrative environments.

As for anomaly detection, a comparison of the traffic in the `goose.csv` and `normal.csv` datasets reveals distinct differences. The normal traffic shows consistent GOOSE activity with minor variation, indicating stable conditions. On the other hand, the `goose` traffic includes sharp spikes in packet aggregation that deviate from the expected pattern (see Figure 3 and Figure 5). These abrupt changes suggest anomalous behavior, possibly due to cyber attacks such as spoofing or replay. Therefore, the `goose.csv` file is most likely to contain anomalous traffic.

2 Traffic Dispersion Graph

A traffic flow graph was generated from the dataset using the NetworkX library. Each node represents a device identified by its source or destination address, while directed edges represent packet transfers between these devices.

2.1 Initial Flow Graph

In the first version of the graph, raw communication flows between GOOSE devices were visualized using NetworkX. As shown in Figure 6, the network consisted of 9 nodes and 5 directed edges, indicating direct device-to-device transmissions among a relatively sparse set of hosts.

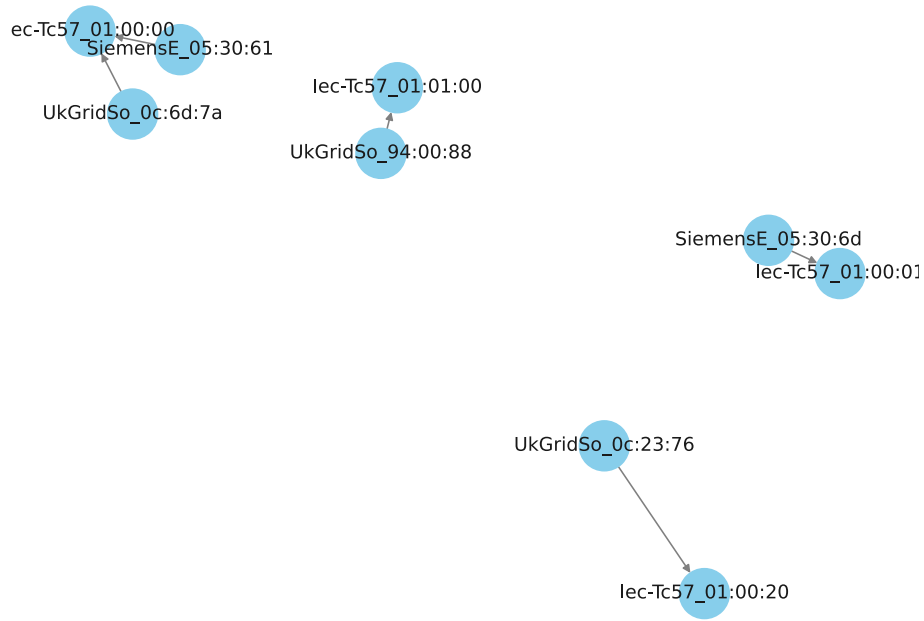


Figure 6: Initial GOOSE traffic flow graph based on original communication pairs

2.2 Switch Node Graph

To better reflect typical OT network topologies, a switch node was added and all traffic was routed through it. This resulted in a denser graph with 10 nodes and 9 edges, as seen in Figure 7. The switch node centralized all communication, significantly increasing its connectivity compared to other nodes.

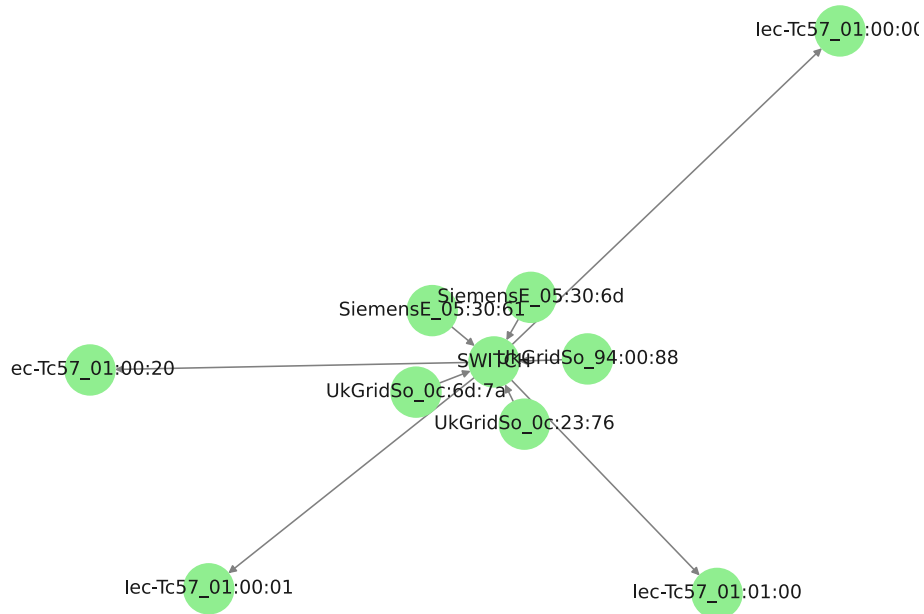


Figure 7: GOOSE traffic graph with all flows routed through a switch node

2.3 Nodes and Characteristics

From both graphs, node centrality and communication roles were inferred. In the raw graph (Figure 6), communication was sparse and point-to-point. In contrast, the switch-based graph (Figure 7) demonstrated star-like topology with the switch node being a central hub. End devices (IEDs) acted either

as senders or receivers, while the switch node facilitated bidirectional communication. The topology reflected typical GOOSE communication behavior in a substation, where multicast frames are disseminated through a common switching infrastructure.